

That's right, Jeopardy works on a buzzer system and Watson was going to have to use it. While initially IBM planned on making a digital buzzer for Watson, the organisers of Jeopardy insisted that it has a physical finger to press a buzzer in order to level the playing field with the humans.

The purpose of this little feature perhaps failed a little in actual practice. In a normal round of Jeopardy, as soon as the quizzer finishes giving the clue, the contestants are free to hit the buzzer. In the case of Watson's match, a text message would be sent to Watson in parallel with the host reading out the clue. As soon as the clue is finished, a little light would come on to indicate that the buzzer is ready to be pressed – and a similar signal is sent to Watson.

As IBM researcher Dr. David Gondek notes in a blog post: “Watson's buzzing is not instantaneous. For some clues he may not complete the question answering computation in time to make the decision to buzz in. For all clues, even if he does have an answer and confidence ready in time, he still has to respond to the signal and physically depress the button.”

“The best human contestants don't wait for, but instead anticipate when the host will finish reading a clue. They time their ‘buzz’ for the instant when the last word leaves his mouth and the “Buzzer Enable” light turns on. Watson cannot anticipate. He can only react to the enable signal. While Watson reacts at an impressive speed, humans can and do buzz in faster than his best possible reaction time.”

Watson competed against two of the most well-known and successful Jeopardy champions – Ken Jennings and Brad Rutter – in a two-match contest aired over three consecutive nights beginning on February 14, 2011. Watson managed to win, of course, getting it the unofficial crown of the smartest AI system in the world.

The problems with Watson

Of course, being able to beat Jennings and Rutter didn't mean that Watson was without problems of its own. As millions witnessed on their television sets, Watson was woefully unaware of its environment, causing it to miss a question. And it was also unable to link different parts of a round together.

The first embarrassing incident was in a clue where Watson failed to recognise what another participant said. After the host read out a clue, Jennings was the first to buzz in with the question: “What are the '20s?” This was deemed incorrect and Watson was the next to buzz in. His question, though, was: “What is 1920s?” Apparently, Watson was unable to sense the